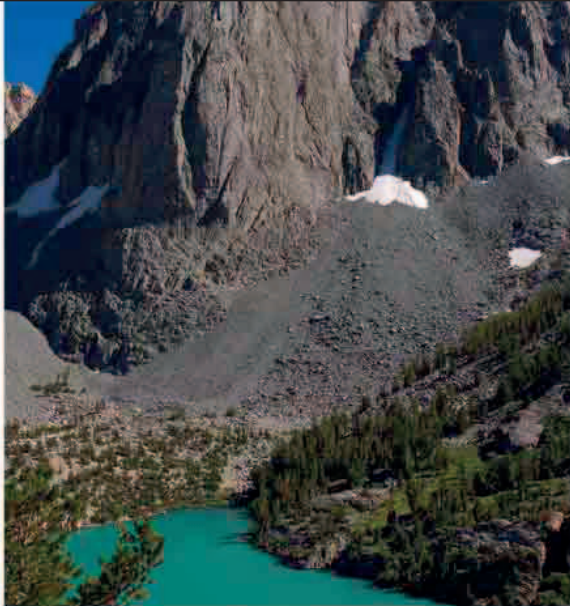




FROST ACTION

In cold places, such as near the poles or high in the mountains, rock is splintered by frost. Water seeps into a crack, then freezes and expands at night, forcing the crack wider. The next day, the ice thaws, allowing more water to enter the crack and freeze the following night. Over time, the crack is wedged apart. Chunks of rock fall away, forming scree slopes at the bases of cliffs.

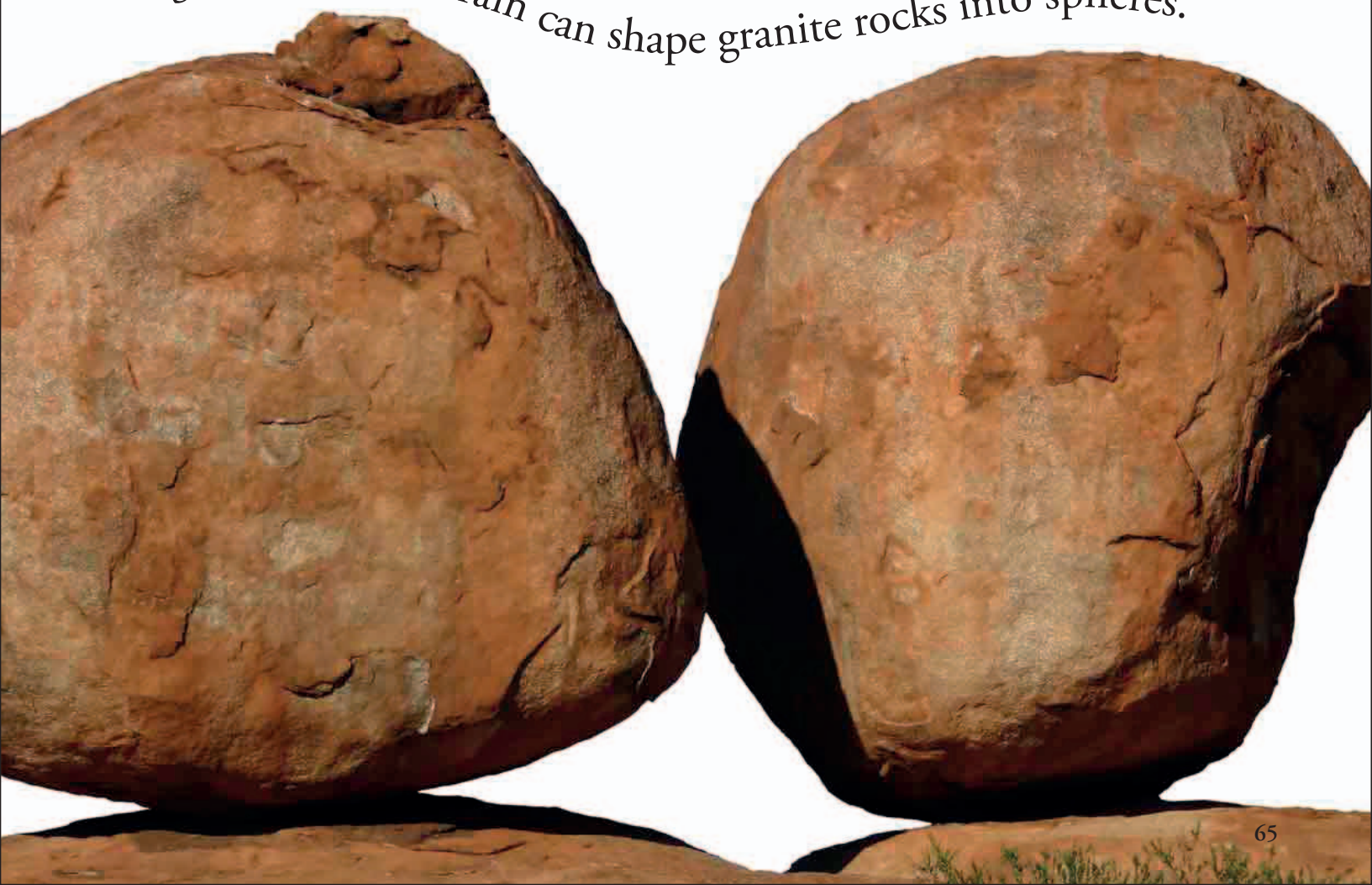
◀ SCREE SLOPE

Rock splintered from this crag by the freeze-thaw process has built up a mass of broken rubble.

BAKING SUN

Hot sun can make the outer layers of rocks crack away in sheets. This is called exfoliation, and is common in deserts with hot days and cold nights. The rock surface expands by day and shrinks at night, becoming detached from the rock underneath. The Devil's Marbles in northern Australia (below) are granite boulders that were created by this process. The image shows the rock surface flaking away.

Sun, wind, and rain can shape granite rocks into spheres.



FACT!

Solid rock pressed down by heavy layers of ice often expands when the ice melts. This can make it crack along lines of weakness and fall apart.

